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Roku launches Howdy, a
\$2.99 ad-free streaming
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Roku is launching an ad-free subscription streaming service called [Howdy](#). The service costs \$2.99 per month and features a library of nearly 10,000 hours of content from its partners, including Lionsgate, Warner Bros. Discovery, and FilmRise, alongside select Roku Original titles.

The company says subscribers will be able to watch titles like “Mad Max: Fury Road,” “The Blind Side,” “Weeds,” and “Kids in the Hall,” as well as rom-coms, medical dramas, ‘90s comedies, and the like.

“Howdy is ad-free and designed to complement, not compete with, premium services,” said Roku founder and CEO Anthony Wood in a [press release](#).

The move comes two months after Roku [paid \\$185 million to acquire Frndly TV](#), a streaming service that offers live TV, on-demand video, and cloud-based DVR.

Howdy joins the company’s Roku Channel, its free, ad-supported (FAST) streaming service. A recent report found that The Roku Channel is the most [popular FAST service](#), ahead of competitors Tubi and Pluto TV. More than 125 million people use the platform every day, Roku says.

A key growth driver for Howdy will be Roku’s organic reach — the company said earlier this year that it had [surpassed 90 million](#) streaming households.

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Roku last week reported its [second-quarter financials](#), turning in better-than-expected revenue growth of 15%, as streaming hours on the platform came in at 35.4 billion, up 5.2 billion hours from a year earlier.

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Aisha Malik

Consumer News Reporter |

Aisha is a consumer news reporter at TechCrunch. Prior to joining the publication in 2021, she was a telecom reporte...

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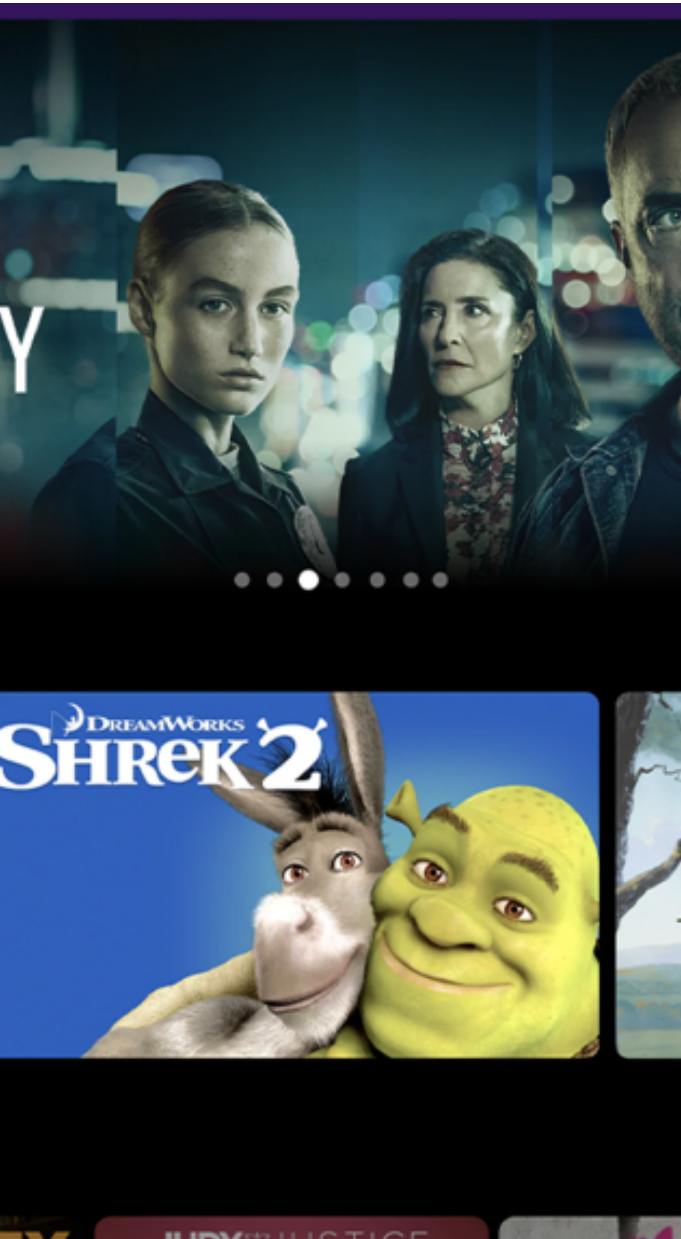


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Free ad-supported TV streaming services are booming, 1 in 3 U.S. viewers tune in

Lauren Forristal — 10:56 AM PDT · August 9, 2023

As more consumers look to cut costs and opt for a free streaming experience, services like Freevee, Pluto TV, Tubi, the Roku Channel and Crackle are seeing significant growth. According to Samba TV's latest [State of Viewership](#) report, 1 in 3 U.S. users subscribe to free ad-supported TV streaming (FAST) services.

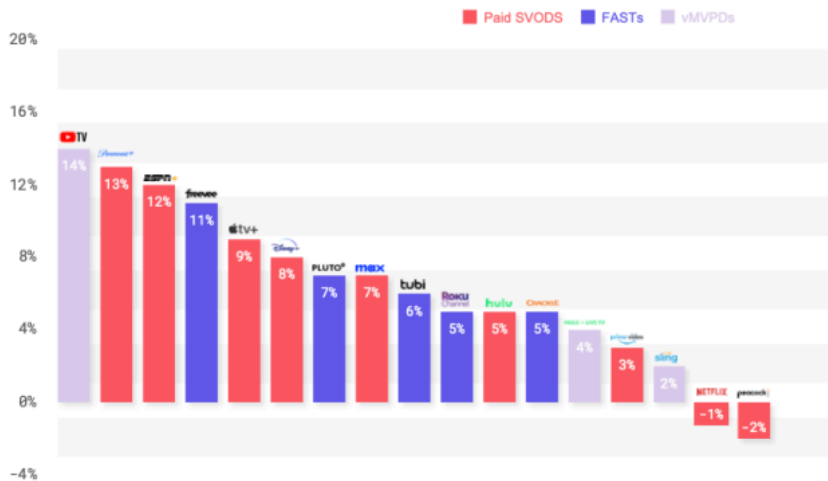
Notably, Amazon's Freevee saw the highest viewership growth in the first half of 2023 compared to competitors, as it was up 11% year-over-year. Amazon has recently ramped up its focus on the

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FAST market, bringing [hundreds of Amazon Original titles](#) from Prime Video to Freevee, as well as [23 new ad-supported TV channels](#) from Warner Bros. Discovery and MGM.

Meanwhile, Pluto and Tubi were up 7% and 6%, respectively, whereas the Roku Channel and Crackle were both up 5%. Fox-owned Tubi touted in its earnings call yesterday that its total consumption grew by 79%, further highlighting the demand for FAST services among viewers.

Growth in video viewership by OTT platform, 2023 vs. 2022
Source: Insider Intelligence | eMarketer, Feb 2023



When we compared this to SVOD (subscription video-on-demand) streamers, a few major platforms saw declines. For instance, Netflix dropped 1% YoY, and Peacock saw a 2% decrease in viewership (maybe don't [kill your free tier](#), Peacock). Even Freevee's sister streaming service, Prime Video, had a mediocre rise in viewership at only 3% YoY.

Cheaper ad-supported streaming options are also being favored over SVOD services. Samba TV reported that 1 in 4 premium streaming subscribers pay for an ad-supported subscription in 2023. Sixty percent of U.S. adults said they would consider subscribing to a "discounted" streaming service if it meant viewing ads, Samba TV added.

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The recent findings come less than a year after [Netflix](#) and [Disney+](#) introduced their ad tiers. According to the report, 85% of participants who are Netflix and Disney+ subscribers said that they signed up for the ads plan soon after it launched.



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Netflix [boasted](#) the success of its ad-supported tier during its first Upfront presentation, revealing that, as of May 2023, the plan has nearly 5 million global monthly active users. For the second quarter of this year, [Antenna](#) recently reported that 17% to 20% of new Netflix signups were for the ad tier.

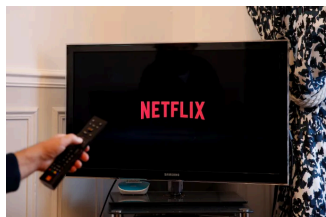
Prime Video may also be getting an ad-supported tier, [according to The Wall Street Journal](#), which reported in June that the e-commerce giant apparently considered an option where existing subscribers would automatically get ads and would have to pay more for ad-free content.

“Streaming first hit audiences as an ad-free, content-when-you-want-it replacement to cable,” Samba TV writes. “But, as these a la carte

streaming options swell, audiences are open to welcoming ads back in if it lowers their monthly costs.”

If premium streaming services continue to hike up their subscription prices, it won’t be a surprise to anyone if this trend of FAST and ad-supported streaming continues its ascent.

Netflix touts nearly 5M monthly active users for ad-supported tier



During Netflix’s first Upfront presentation on Wednesday, Netflix revealed that its ad plan has nearly five million global monthly active users. This is the first time the company has disclosed figures for the new tier

— which only launched six months ago — and the number is certainly notable. In March, Bloomberg reported that one million ... [Continue reading](#)

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Lauren Forristal



Lauren covers media, streaming, apps and platforms at TechCrunch.

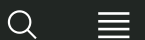
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Discovery+ becomes The Roku Channel Premium Subscription's first ad-supported plan offering

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With over 200 originals, making it the largest mixture of library titles on The Roku Channel.

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Roku says both the ad-free (\$6.99/month) and ad-supported (\$4.99/month) versions of discovery+ are now available, and users can sign up for a free seven-day trial.

The addition is notable because it's the first time Roku's Premium Subscriptions will support a

AI



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Sarah Perez - 12 hours ago

subscription video-on-demand service with an ad tier. Typically, The Roku Channel generates revenue by running its ads across the free movies and TV shows it streams as well as by taking a revenue share from the premium subscriptions it sells to its customers. But these days, more subscription video services include both ad-free and ad-supported tiers to choose from.

Today's move opens the door for Roku to connect subscribers to more services like discovery+ through The Roku Channel hub in the future.

Randy Ahn, head of The Roku Channel, SVOD, said in a statement, "Today marks an exciting milestone for our business as we welcome both tiers of discovery+ to the roster of exceptional services available as a Premium Subscription on The Roku Channel. Discovery+ is a leading streaming service and features an unmatched content library. We're thrilled to support their growth through their launch on The Roku Channel and for the opportunity to bring this caliber of content to our users."

Discovery+ offers viewers access to shows from brands like HGTV, Food Network, TLC, ID, OWN, Travel Channel, Discovery Channel, Animal Planet, Magnolia Network, as well as content from A&E, The History Channel and Lifetime.

The Roku Channel, meanwhile, offers premium subscriptions to more than 50 services and gives users a unified browse and sign-up experience, allowing for simple subscription management with a single monthly bill.

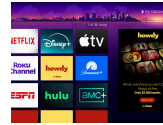
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It recently announced more Roku Originals coming to the platform including [new cooking shows](#) hosted by Martha Stewart and other well-known food media names. There will also be lifestyle and home improvement programs coming to the free streaming platform, as well.

Roku snags Martha Stewart, Emeril and others for its original programming push



It is the second day of NewFronts, and the announcements continue. Roku today said it will extend its content library in hopes to target audiences who are fans of lifestyle, cooking, home renovation and

reality television. The company has two new co-production deals with Marquee Brands and Milk Street Studios, giving

The Roku Channel seven [Continue reading](#)

“We’re pleased to deepen our relationship with Roku, a valued partner, and expand access of discovery+ on the Roku platform through the launch on The Roku Channel,” said Gabriel Sauerhoff, SVP Digital Distribution and Commercial Partnerships, Warner. Bros. Discovery, “We look forward to further extending the reach of our exceptional library of lifestyle and real-life content to millions of

Roku streamers and providing them increased optionality in how they access discovery+ .”

The five-year-old Roku Channel is doing well for the company, recently reporting a total of [20.9 billion streaming hours](#), per Roku’s recent quarterly earnings report.

Discovery+ is a younger streaming service, only one years old, and will soon [merge](#) with HBO Max. Last month, parent company Warner Bros. Discovery reported that Discovery Inc. had [24 million total streaming subscribers](#) as of the end of Q1.

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Lauren Forristal

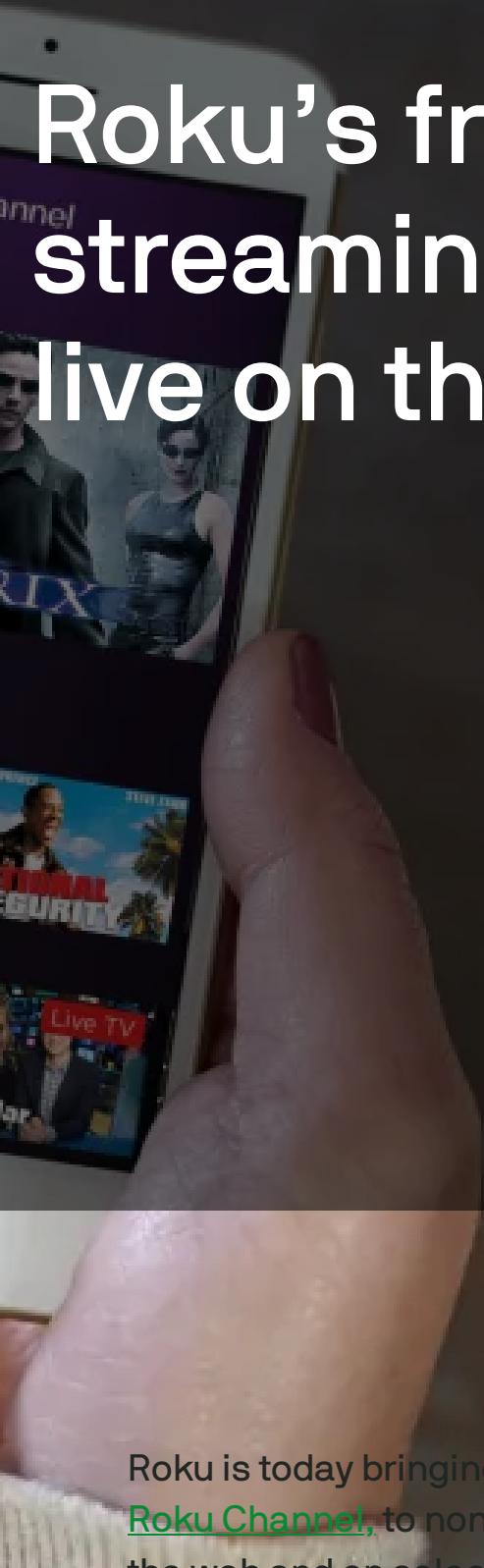


Lauren covers media, streaming, apps and platforms at TechCrunch.

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Roku's free, ad-supported streaming channel is now live on the web



Roku's homepage also expanded to include 'Featured Free' content

Sarah Perez

12:59 PM PDT · August 8, 2018

Roku is today bringing its free, streaming entertainment destination, [The Roku Channel](#), to non-Roku devices for the first time, with a launch on both the web and on select Samsung smart TVs, ahead of a wider cross-platform rollout. The channel, which offers free, ad-supported movies and TV shows, will be available across PCs, mobile phones and tablets, the company says. In addition, Roku is updating the navigation on its own devices, including Roku players and Roku TVs, to include a new feature called "Featured Free," which will directly point users to free content from The Roku Channel, as well as other apps, like ABC, The CW, CW Seed, Fox, Freeform, Pluto TV, Sony Crackle, Tubi and more.

The Roku Channel [first launched last September](#), as a way for Roku to differentiate its connected media devices and TVs running Roku software from rivals like Amazon Fire TV, Apple TV and Chromecast.

Despite Roku's popularity — it's [leading the internet video streaming device market](#) — the company hadn't really used its platform to promote its own content — the way Amazon pushes Prime Video shows on Fire TV owners, for example — until then.



The channel itself is populated with movies that Roku gained access to through licensing deals with studios like Lionsgate, MGM, Paramount, Sony Pictures Entertainment and Warner Brothers. However, it also leveraged Roku's strength as a platform by pulling in free content from its existing channel partners (with permission), including American Classics, FilmRise, Nosey, OVGuide, Popcornflix, Vidmark and YuYu.

The content itself is monetized through advertising, which Roku's in-house ad sales team is in charge of selling, with some portion going to partners. The company's goal has been to smartly place the ads to respect the content they interrupt, and not to inundate viewers with the same ad over and over again.

With the channel's expansion to the web and other TV platforms, Roku can further grow its advertising business, while also making the case for itself as a device platform. For existing Roku device owners, the channel is just another value-add for being a Roku user — and one that may keep them from jumping ship to another player in the future.

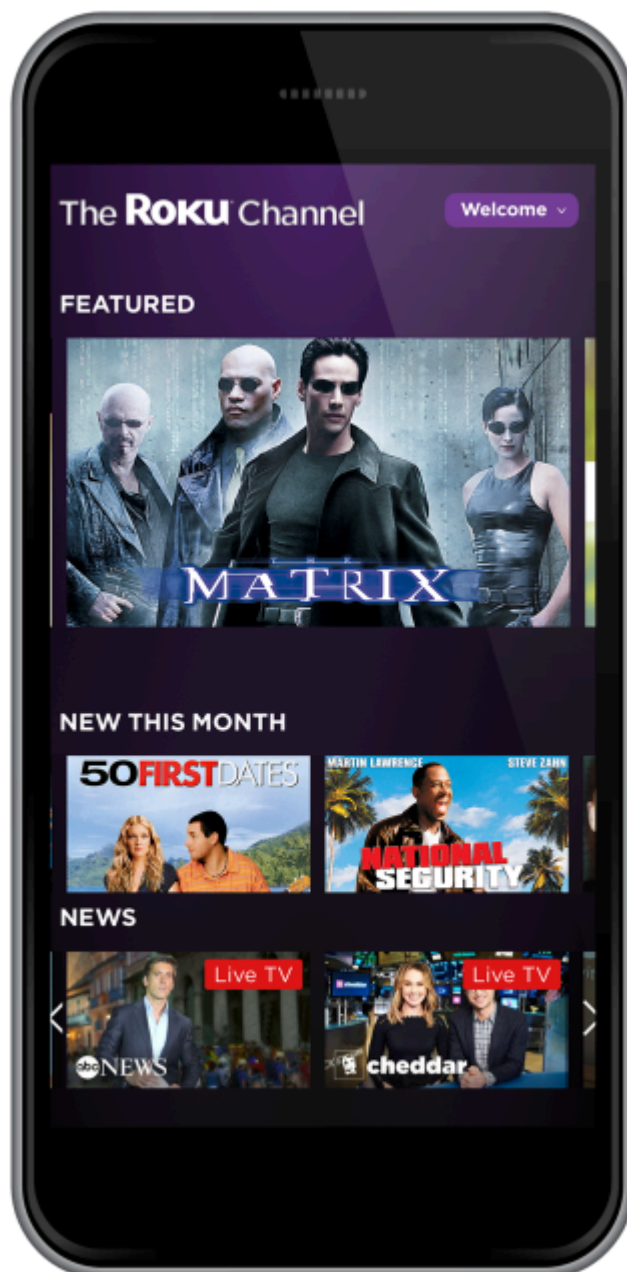


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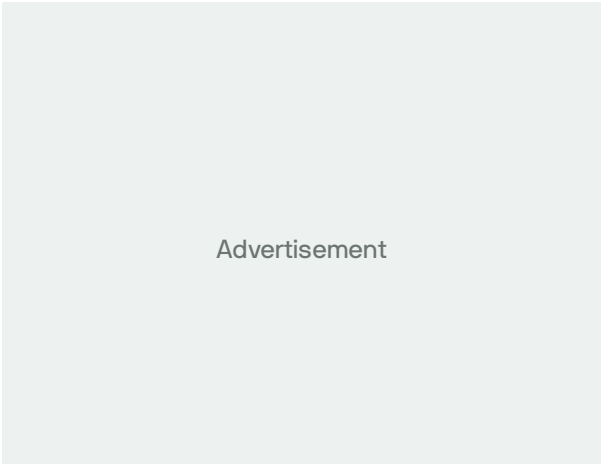
*Titles are subject to availability

“Roku is the leading platform for free entertainment and our users love it. We’re delighted to deliver even more value to our customers without

subscriptions, complicated logins or fees,” said Rob Holmes, Roku’s vice president of Programming and Engagement, in a statement about today’s expansion. “By expanding The Roku Channel to the Web, we’re broadening the access points to high-quality, free streaming entertainment. With Featured Free, we’re making it easy for our customers to see the great, free content already available on the Roku platform in one place, while creating value for our content providers by connecting them with Roku’s growing audience.”

Meanwhile, Roku is again taking advantage of its platform nature with the launch of the “Featured Free” section on its home screen.

This top-level navigational menu — just above “My Feed” on Roku’s home screen — will include a list of popular free content from its channel partners. The shows are identified by name and include a thumbnail image, but it doesn’t indicate which partner’s channel they’re coming from. And, when launched, customers are taken directly to the content itself.



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This section will include the latest in-season episodes of top network shows, full past-season catch-ups, classic series and hit movies.

The news of these launches follows [a recent report from Variety](#) that claimed Roku is planning to launch its own Amazon Channels-like subscription marketplace, as well. The report said Roku would bring together a number of paid subscription services into the same section, to make it easier for consumers to subscribe to paid channels without needing to first find the right app.

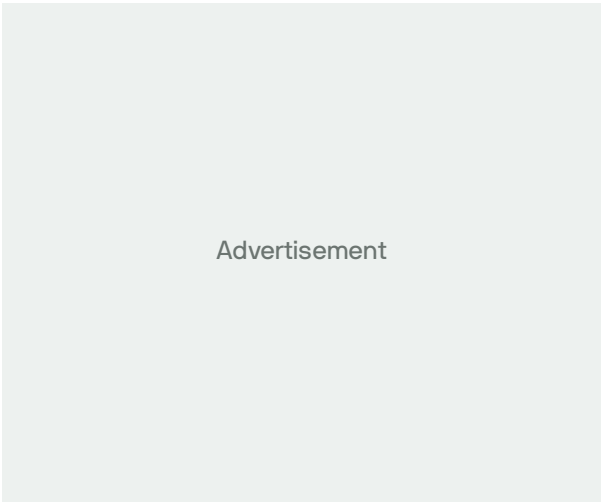
The “Featured Free” section paints a good picture of what this new subscription marketplace could look like — a single destination where the content itself, and not the channel it comes from, is what’s highlighted.

These new features also indicate a shift in Roku’s larger business from being fully reliant on device sales, to transitioning more into services; for now, specifically ad-supported services.

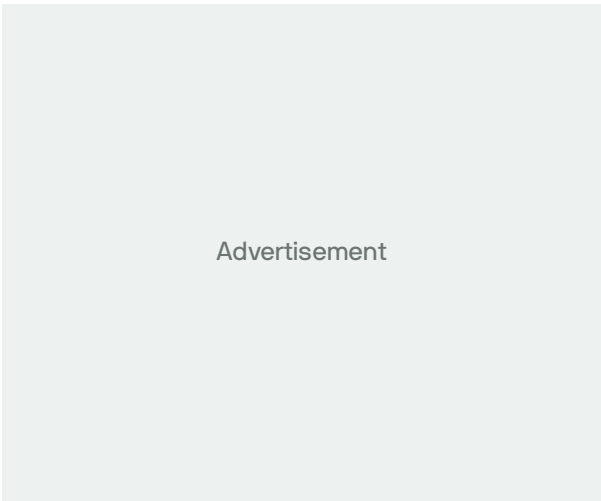
Roku is expected to report its [earnings](#) later today, after the market’s close, so the timing of the launches is not coincidental. Wall Street is [expecting](#) a net loss of \$0.15 per share, down from \$0.18 in the year-ago quarter, and sales up 41.46 percent to reach \$99.6 million, in Q2. Overall, analysts predict Roku will report annual sales of \$697.9 million.

Roku says the “Featured Free” section will begin to roll out to U.S. users starting today, and will reach all customers over the weeks ahead.

The Roku Channel, meanwhile, is available on the web as of now, via [TheRokuChannel.com](#).



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Sarah Perez

Consumer News Editor | [X](#) [🦋](#) [@](#) [in](#)

Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having previously spent over three years at ReadWriteWeb. Prior to her work as a reporter, Sarah worked in I.T....

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